What Is Wilson Actually Saying?

Evaluating the criticism of His Views Stated in "Reforming Marriage"

First, I want to acknowledge many posting on this topic sincerely care about husband/wife issues and seek the good of marriage, as do we all. Marriage is the cornerstone of Christian civilization.

An important note to consider right off the bat is this: The folks arguing against Doug Wilson's beliefs want their feelings to be understood and affirmed. However, the passionate depth of one's feelings does not make every feeling or interpretation authoritative.

That said, I wish to introduce a teaching card I produced called, "Eight Steps to Evaluate a Teacher". (See attached) Those eight principles are:

1. Identify exactly what was said
2. Determine whether it is actually wrong
3. State the error precisely
4. Determine the seriousness of the error
5. Ask whether the error is isolated or systemic
6. Adjust trust proportionately
7. Continue testing individual claims on their merits
8. Hold fast to what is good.

(The last two are drawn specifically from 1 Thessalonians 5:21.)

Now that's on the table, let's examine the blog post and the claims accordingly.

I think there are really two questions here. First, what is Doug Wilson actually saying? Then Second, is what he's saying biblical? We ought to keep those questions separate. Before we decide whether Wilson is right or wrong, we owe a duty to righteousness to be sure folks are criticizing the position he actually holds.

And I want to be careful here. Wilson sometimes uses deliberately provocative language. Given that, is it even remotely fair to take one provocative sentence, give it the worst possible meaning, and then condemn him for the meaning supplied?

The Sentence We Are Arguing About

Wilson says wives need to be led "with a firm hand," and that a husband must give his wife what the Bible says she needs rather than simply what she says she needs **(pp. 61–62).** That's what the post says and they accurately lift that from his book. And that is certainly stronger than merely saying, "God knows best." Wilson is making a claim *about* marriage. He believes the husband has a real responsibility to lead.

So it would be wrong to water that down. He sincerely believes in biblical husbandly headship. He believes there are times when a husband should not simply surrender his judgment because his wife disagrees with him.

But that is a long way from saying, what posters have characterized him as saying, "A godly husband should not listen to his wife." That is clearly where the criticism starts putting words into Wilson's mouth.

(For a more in-depth understanding of 'Firm Hand' see teaching card page 8)

Does Wilson Teach a Husband Not to Listen to His Wife?

No. In fact, Wilson's own argument depends upon the husband needing his wife. He says Adam could not accomplish the task God gave him alone. The woman was created as a helper comparable to him. Wilson calls marriage "companionship in the labor of dominion" and says the husband cannot fulfill this part of his calling in isolation **(p. 16).**

That matters. The wife is not an unnecessary passenger while the husband drives the family bus. She is necessary to the mission God gave them.

Wilson goes even further. He says a godly husband uses his strength to ***give*** to his wife, not to take from her, and he criticizes husbands who fail to accept their wives' necessary help **(pp. 26–27).**

So if the charge is that Wilson teaches husbands, "Don't listen to your wives," well, I just don't see that in any of his writings, much less *Reforming Marriage*. What I see is something different: listen to her, receive her help, love her sacrificially — ***but*** do not use listening to her as an excuse to abdicate the responsibility God gave you.

What About Her 'Agency in Saying What She Needs'?

Of course she can. Nothing Wilson says takes away her ability to speak, disagree, ask questions, express concerns, or tell her husband what she thinks she needs.

In fact, Wilson gives examples of wives doing exactly that. They come to their husbands for counsel. They ask for decisions. They sometimes resist those decisions. His examples assume an active wife who is talking to her husband, not a silent woman who has been stripped of agency **(pp. 63–64).**

But here is the part of Wilson's position I think we should simply acknowledge: he does not believe a wife simply saying, "This is what I need," necessarily settles the question of what she actually needs.

And why would it? Husbands can be wrong about what they themselves need. It's called self-deception and the Bible is full of it. Likewise, wives too can be wrong about what ***they*** need. The final standard for a Christian is not "what I feel I need." The final standard is God's Word.

Now that raises the harder question: what happens when husband and wife ***disagree*** about what Scripture requires? That is where Wilson's doctrine of headship comes in.

Does Wilson Give the Husband Real Authority?

Yes. We shouldn't dodge that either. Wilson does not teach an egalitarian marriage in which husband and wife hold identical offices.

When a wife comes to her husband asking for counsel, Wilson says he should give her counsel. When she asks him to make a decision, he says he should make one. And he does not think the husband should automatically abandon that decision simply because she pushes back **(pp. 63–64).**

Someone can disagree with that. But disagreeing with it is not the same thing as saying Wilson teaches that the husband gets to do whatever he wants. And that when he does, it is an absolute expression of oppression and evil.

Wilson specifically says, "Christ is the Lord of marriage—not the husband, and not the wife" **(p. 53).**

That sentence is important. The husband is not sovereign. He is ***under*** authority himself. He does not get to say, "I am the husband, therefore whatever I want is what God wants." That would destroy Wilson's own argument.

Headship, as Wilson presents it, is an office ***under*** Christ. And with that office comes responsibility. The husband has more responsibility, not more human value.

Can a Husband Ever Go Against What His Wife Says She Wants?

According to Wilson, yes. And again, I don't think we should pretend otherwise.

The immediate example is a wife who says she wants to be left alone. Wilson argues that Ephesians 5:25 does not permit a husband simply to walk away from his responsibility to love her and remain engaged **(p. 62).**

So yes, Wilson believes there are times when faithful headship may mean ***not*** doing what the wife presently says she wants.

But notice what has happened in the criticism. That proposition gets turned into something much larger: "The husband has authority, therefore he can ignore his wife and decide what she needs." That does not follow.

Wilson says immediately in this discussion that the husband's authority must be exercised with a Christ-like disposition to service and never in a self-seeking way **(p. 61).**

That is a very different thing from male autonomy. Biblical authority is always ***delegated*** authority. The husband is ***accountable*** to the One who gave him the office.

What About the Word "Dominance"?

This is probably Wilson at his most Wilson-esque. He deliberately uses a word he knows people are going to react to.

He does actually say a husband's "dominance" is a fact. But then immediately makes a distinction: the question is whether that dominance will be "loving and constructive dominion" or "hateful and destructive tyranny" **(p. 21).**

Those are not small qualifications. They ***are*** the point.

Wilson even says an absent or passive husband can dominate a home by his absence. The empty chair at the table can dominate the family **(pp. 20–21).** So he is using "dominance" more broadly than we normally use the word today.

I might choose a different word. But if we are evaluating Wilson fairly, we need to use Wilson's definition rather than substituting another.

But Aren't Men and Women Equal?

Yes. And this is where I think one of the most important distinctions gets lost.

Equality does not necessarily mean sameness.

Wilson agrees that husband and wife participate together in the dominion mandate. (This is one area of agreement with a Facebook poster who said, 'we both are called to dominion'.) In fact Wilson calls marriage 'companionship in the labor of dominion' **(p. 16).**

So saying, "But women have dominion too," does not actually answer Wilson. He already believes that.

The real question is whether sharing the same dignity and the same mission requires husband and wife to hold the same office.

Wilson says no. He sees one mission with ordered roles. Husband and wife are both image-bearers. Both are necessary. Both serve Christ. Both participate in the work God has given mankind. But they do not therefore have identical responsibilities within marriage.

That is the issue we ought to argue from Scripture.

Does This Put Husband and Wife Against Each Other?

I don't think it does. At least that is certainly not what Wilson is trying to construct.

His whole Genesis argument is the man needs the woman. He cannot accomplish the task alone **(p. 16)**. And his description of masculine strength is not strength used to get something from her, but strength used to give something to her **(p. 26).**

That is not husband versus wife. It is husband and wife under Christ, serving one mission, with different responsibilities.

Now, sinful men can turn headship into tyranny. Of course they can. Sin can corrupt every good thing God gives us. But the abuse of an office does not prove that the office itself is abusive.

Where I Think the Real Disagreement Is

I think we can clear away a lot of the argument by asking one question:

Does God give a husband an office of headship in marriage that his wife does not equally hold over him?

If the answer is no, then of course Wilson's entire framework is going to look wrong.

But if the answer is yes — if Ephesians 5 really does identify the husband as head in a way patterned after Christ and the Church — then we have to ask what that headship actually requires. We cannot make it disappear simply because bad men might abuse it.

And that is why I think the argument needs to come back to Scripture.

Nobody needs to defend every sentence Doug Wilson ever wrote. But if we are going to accuse him of teaching oppression, denying a wife's agency, telling husbands not to listen to their wives, or giving men unlimited authority, then we ought to be able to show that from what he ***actually*** teaches.

I don't think the quote on the post from *Reforming Marriage* supports those charges.

What it does support is a strong doctrine of husbandly headship: authority under Christ, responsibility for the home, sacrificial love toward the wife, and a wife whose help is not optional but necessary to the shared work God has given them.

That is the position that should be tested. Not the caricature. The position itself.

Page References in Reforming Marriage

Douglas Wilson, Reforming Marriage, rev. ed. (Canon Press, 2005).

Subject	**Page**
Helpful companionship; wife necessary to the labor of dominion	p. 16
Husbandly dominance; constructive dominion versus destructive tyranny	pp. 20–21
Godly strength gives rather than takes; husband receives wife's necessary help	pp. 26–27
“Christ is the Lord of marriage—not the husband, and not the wife”	p. 53
Authority exercised with a Christ-like disposition to service	p. 61
“Firm hand”; what Scripture says she needs versus what she says she needs	p. 62
Wife asks for counsel/decision; husband responds and does not simply abdicate	pp. 63–64

2 EIGHT STEPS TO EVALUATE A TEACHER

WHEN A SERIOUS ERROR IS DISCOVERED

1. IDENTIFY EXACTLY WHAT WAS SAID.
Avoid reacting to paraphrases, clips, headlines, or secondhand descriptions.

2. DETERMINE WHETHER IT IS ACTUALLY WRONG.
Compare the claim with Scripture and sound reasoning.

3. STATE THE ERROR PRECISELY.
Criticize what the person actually said, not the worst possible interpretation.

4. DETERMINE THE SERIOUSNESS OF THE ERROR.
Not every mistake is heresy.
Not every poor judgment is apostasy.

5. ASK WHETHER THE ERROR IS ISOLATED OR SYSTEMIC.
Does it reveal a deeper premise that appears elsewhere?

6. ADJUST TRUST PROPORTIONATELY.
A pattern of error warrants greater caution than an isolated mistake.

7. CONTINUE TESTING INDIVIDUAL CLAIMS ON THEIR MERITS.
Do not let the person's reputation substitute for evaluating the argument.

8. HOLD FAST WHAT IS GOOD.
Do not discard truth because it came through an imperfect messenger.

OUR ALLEGIANCE IS TO TRUTH, NOT TO PERSONALITIES.

TRUTH FROM A FLAWED PERSON IS STILL TRUTH.

FALSEHOOD FROM A RESPECTED PERSON IS STILL FALSEHOOD.

SCRIPTURE ALONE IS INFALLIBLE.

OUR GUIDING SCRIPTURE

"Test everything; hold fast what is good."
— 1 THESSALONIANS 5:21

Discernment is not gullibility. Cancellation is not wisdom.

TEST EVERYTHING. HOLD FAST WHAT IS GOOD.
THAT IS THE CHRISTIAN WAY.

KINGDOM MARRIAGE

ONE MISSION · ORDERED ROLES · LASTING JOY

WHAT DOES "FIRM HAND" MEAN?

IN DOUG WILSON'S *REFORMING MARRIAGE*

A BIBLICAL AND PRACTICAL EXPLANATION

1 THE CONTEXT: LOVE THAT LEADS

Wilson's "firm hand" comes in the context of Ephesians 5:25, where the husband must love his wife as Christ loved the Church—sacrificially, steadfastly, and for her good. This love does not walk away or stand by when leadership is difficult.

Ephesians 5:25–29

Reforming Marriage, pp. 61–62

2 WHAT "FIRM" MEANS

Firm **means steadfast**—refusing to abandon the responsibility of headship when it becomes uncomfortable. It means exercising judgment under God's Word, making a decision, and not caving merely because your wife disagrees.

Genesis 3:17

1 Corinthians 11:3

Reforming Marriage, pp. 63–64

3 WHAT "FIRM" DOES NOT MEAN

Firm **does not mean** harsh, domineering, intimidating, dismissive, or using strength to get your way. Scripture expressly forbids husbands from being harsh with their wives and requires them to live with their wives with understanding and honor.

Colossians 3:19

1 Peter 3:7

Reforming Marriage, pp. 26–27

4 LISTEN — BUT DON'T ABDICATE

A godly husband listens to his wife, receives her help, and values her as a necessary partner in the mission God has given. The wife is not an unnecessary passenger; she is a helper comparable to him. But listening does not mean surrendering the responsibility God has given you.

Genesis 2:18

Reforming Marriage, pp. 16, 26–27

5 HEADSHIP ≠ INFALLIBILITY

Headship is responsibility, not superior competence. A wife can ask, "This is what I need," and her words deserve to be heard. But her statement does not necessarily settle the question. Both husbands and wives can be wrong about what they need (self-deception is real). The final standard is God's Word.

Proverbs 14:12

Jeremiah 17:9

Romans 3:23

6 THE GUARDRAIL: CHRIST IS HEAD

The husband is himself under authority. The head of the man is Christ (1 Corinthians 11:3). A godly husband uses his strength to give to his wife, not to take from her. His authority is always exercised under Christ's lordship and for the good of his wife.

1 Corinthians 11:3

Reforming Marriage, pp. 26–27

LISTEN ≠ ABDICATE

Genesis 21:12
A POSITIVE EXAMPLE

God told Abraham to "listen to the voice of Sarah." Husbands should listen. A wife can speak, ask questions, disagree, and express what she thinks she needs.

Genesis 3:17
A CAUTIONARY EXAMPLE

Adam is condemned for "listening to the voice of his wife" and disobeying God. Listening cannot mean abdicating responsibility.

THE REAL ISSUE

The question isn't whether a husband listens. He should. The question is whether listening means surrendering his responsibility to judge everything under God's Word.

KEY TRUTHS

- Firm hand flows from sacrificial love, not ego.
- It means steadfastness, not harshness.
- It includes listening, receiving help, and valuing your wife's counsel.
- It does not make a wife's statement about her needs the final authority.
- The husband remains under Christ's authority.



CARRY TRUTH

FIRM DOESN'T MEAN HARSH. IT MEANS STEADFAST.

Listen to her. Receive her help. Love her sacrificially. But don't abdicate the responsibility God gave you.

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